

Behavioral Interview — Q&A Preparation

Sr. Delivery Solutions Architect | Databricks | 15 'Tell Me About a Time' Questions with Full STAR Answers

How to use this guide: Read each answer aloud before the interview. Internalize the STAR structure, then speak naturally — don't memorize word-for-word. Each answer includes a delivery tip in the shaded box to coach your framing on the day.

QUESTION 1 OF 15

Tell me about a time you led the end-to-end delivery of a complex data platform from design to production.

[DSA Core | Technical Delivery | Business Value]

S — Situation

Verizon needed a cloud-native Supply Chain data platform to give its major US OEM partners and 3PL logistics providers real-time visibility into inventory and order flows. The existing state was fragmented — each partner was exchanging data through ad-hoc file transfers, with no single source of truth, causing costly inventory miscalculations.

T — Task

As the Sr. Solutions Architect and accountable technical owner, I was responsible for the full delivery: architecture design, pipeline engineering direction, partner integration, stakeholder governance, and go-live. No delivery playbook existed — I had to create it.

A — Action

I started with a discovery phase to map every data source, latency requirement, and partner data contract. I designed a JIT (just-in-time) architecture on AWS combining real-time ingestion via event-driven pipelines with batch reconciliation for overnight settlement data. I established a governance cadence with both internal engineering leads and external OEM stakeholders, ran architecture design reviews to validate trade-offs (Lambda vs. EMR for streaming, schema versioning strategy), and built an enablement plan for the data engineering team to own the platform post-launch. I tracked progress weekly against go-live milestones and reported investment health to senior stakeholders throughout.

R — Result

The platform went live and generated over \$20M in annual working capital savings through improved data visibility and reduced inventory waste. It became the reference architecture for subsequent supply chain integrations at Verizon.

Delivery Tip: Lead with the \$20M outcome immediately — Brandon thinks in business value. Then walk the technical choices. Avoid getting lost in AWS service names; anchor on the architecture decisions and why.

QUESTION 2 OF 15

Tell me about a time you identified an opportunity for AI or automation that others hadn't seen, and drove it to production.

[Initiative | Agentic AI | Driving Adoption]

S — Situation

At Verizon, a set of critical operational workflows in our data platform required manual analyst intervention to process, classify, and route data events — a cycle that took days to weeks depending on volume and complexity. The process was accepted as a known inefficiency.

T — Task

No one had asked me to fix it. I saw the opportunity to apply LLM-based automation and took it upon myself to build the business case, design the solution, and drive it to production.

A — Action

I prototyped an Agentic AI pipeline using Python, LangChain, and OpenAI APIs that could autonomously process, classify, and route the data events that previously required manual handling. I built a RAG-backed context layer so the agent could reason over historical decisions and make accurate classifications. I presented the prototype to engineering and product leadership with a clear ROI story — hours saved per week, error rate reduction, cycle time compression — to secure production approval. I then worked with the data engineering team to integrate the agent into the production data platform with appropriate guardrails, monitoring, and fallback logic.

R — Result

The initiative compressed process cycles from weeks to near-real-time, reclaiming thousands of analyst hours annually. It became a proof-of-concept that influenced the broader AI integration strategy across the data platform.

Delivery Tip: This is your strongest AI story. Brandon will connect it directly to Databricks Mosaic AI and Genie use cases. Emphasize that you drove it without being asked — that signals DSA-level initiative.

QUESTION 3 OF 15

Tell me about a time you had to manage a critical escalation with a senior executive under pressure.

[Executive Escalation | Trusted Advisor | Accountability]

S — Situation

While owning the B2B Billing data platform at Verizon — which served over 2,000 enterprise clients — a data discrepancy surfaced in the billing traceability pipeline that affected invoices for a set of high-value enterprise accounts. The error had propagated through transformation and validation stages before being caught in auditing, raising questions about the integrity of the entire pipeline.

T — Task

As the accountable technical owner for the platform, I was the first point of contact. I had to manage both the technical resolution and the executive communication — including updates to VP-level stakeholders — simultaneously.

A — Action

I immediately isolated the scope of the impact, identifying which client accounts were affected and which billing cycles were at risk. I assembled a small working group of data and platform engineers, established an hourly internal status cadence, and personally led root cause analysis. In parallel, I drafted a clear executive communication: not a technical deep-dive, but a structured narrative with (1) what happened, (2) which clients were affected and how, (3) what we were doing to fix it, and (4) when we expected resolution. I gave executives a confident timeline — not hedging — and updated them proactively at each milestone rather than waiting to be asked. Once resolved, I led a post-mortem and implemented additional validation gates and

alerting to prevent recurrence.

R — Result

The issue was resolved within the committed timeline. The executive communication was cited by my manager as a model for how to handle production escalations — transparency, structure, and certainty even in ambiguity.

Delivery Tip: The key message Brandon is listening for: you give executives certainty, not hedging. Say exactly that. The detail about structured communication — not a technical dump — will land well with a former DSA.

QUESTION 4 OF 15

Tell me about a time you drove the adoption of a new platform or technical practice across a team that was resistant.

[Enablement | Change Management | Influence]

S — Situation

At Verizon, after establishing the cloud-native data platform reference architecture on AWS, I needed the broader data engineering and solution architecture communities to adopt standardized integration design patterns and pipeline best practices. Teams had developed their own approaches over years and saw the new standards as added overhead.

T — Task

My role was not just to design the architecture, but to drive adoption — without direct authority over the engineering teams.

A — Action

I took a show-don't-tell approach. I started by embedding myself in the teams' regular architecture reviews, not to mandate, but to demonstrate how the patterns applied to their specific use cases. I created lightweight, practical documentation — reference architectures, integration design playbooks, code templates — that made adoption easier than doing it from scratch. I ran internal tech talks and workshops using real examples from the Supply Chain and Billing platforms as proof points, connecting the patterns directly to outcomes the teams cared about: fewer production incidents, faster go-lives, cleaner data. I also worked with engineering leads to get the patterns incorporated into team onboarding and code review checklists.

R — Result

The reference architectures and design patterns were adopted across multiple engineering teams and became the standard for new data platform initiatives at Verizon. Mentorship requests from data engineers increased as the patterns demonstrated value in production.

Delivery Tip: Frame this as a user growth and enablement story — exactly what DSAs do post-win. Use the phrase 'show-don't-tell.' Brandon will recognize that as the right instinct.

QUESTION 5 OF 15

Tell me about a time you translated an ambiguous business problem into a concrete technical architecture.

[Discovery | Architecture | Business-Technical Bridge]

S — Situation

At the start of the Supply Chain platform engagement at Verizon, the business requirement was expressed in purely commercial terms: 'We need better visibility into our supply chain.' There was no defined data model, no agreement on which systems were sources of truth, and no consensus on what 'visibility' meant to different stakeholders.

T — Task

I needed to take that open-ended mandate and translate it into a technical architecture with defined scope, data contracts, and delivery milestones — before a single line of code was written.

A — Action

I ran a structured discovery phase: I held stakeholder workshops with supply chain operations, finance, and engineering to surface the underlying decisions that needed to be made — which data, at what latency, for which users, driving which operational decisions. I built an event-mapping exercise to trace each business outcome back to specific data flows and sources. From that, I produced an architecture proposal with three options (phased complexity), each with trade-offs on cost, latency, and time-to-value. I presented these to both technical and business stakeholders, facilitated alignment on the right option, and converted the agreed architecture into a delivery plan with milestones, owners, and success metrics.

R — Result

The discovery process collapsed weeks of potential rework by aligning stakeholders before development began. The agreed architecture became the foundation of the \$20M Supply Chain platform.

Delivery Tip: This is a pure trusted advisor story. Lead with the discovery workshops — that's a core DSA competency. Phrase it as: 'I create certainty from uncertainty — that's the job.'

QUESTION 6 OF 15

Tell me about a time you managed multiple complex programmes simultaneously and had to prioritize under pressure.

[Prioritization | Programme Management | Stakeholder Management]

S — Situation

As Sr. Solutions Architect at Verizon, I simultaneously owned the technical direction for multiple enterprise data platform initiatives — including the Supply Chain platform, the B2B Billing platform, and the Agentic AI initiative — each with distinct stakeholders, engineering teams, and delivery timelines. Competing demands frequently created prioritization conflicts.

T — Task

I needed to maintain technical accountability across all programmes without any of them falling behind, while being transparent with stakeholders about where focus was being applied and why.

A — Action

I built a simple but structured view of each programme's health across four dimensions: business risk if delayed, proximity to go-live, depth of blocker, and strategic value. This gave me a defensible prioritization framework I could communicate to stakeholders — not just 'I'm busy,' but 'here's why use case X is getting my attention this week and what we're doing to keep use case Y moving.' I delegated deep technical tasks to engineers where possible and kept my own involvement concentrated on blockers, architecture decisions, and stakeholder communication. I ran weekly governance touchpoints for each programme to maintain visibility without creating overhead.

R — Result

All three programmes progressed to key milestones in parallel without a single escalation attributed to prioritization mismanagement. The governance model I built for multi-programme oversight was adopted by other architects on the team.

Delivery Tip: Brandon manages a team of DSAs who each carry multiple accounts. He's looking for evidence you can self-direct and build structure without being told how. Describe the framework, not just the hustle.

QUESTION 7 OF 15

Tell me about a time you had to build a trusted relationship with a stakeholder who was initially skeptical of you or your approach.

[Trusted Advisor | Stakeholder Trust | Technical Credibility]

S — Situation

When I inherited ownership of the B2B Billing data platform at Verizon, the finance operations stakeholders who depended on it had experienced reliability issues from a previous architecture iteration. They were skeptical about proposed changes to the data traceability pipeline and reluctant to engage in collaborative planning.

T — Task

I needed to earn their trust before they would give me the access and candid input needed to do the job well.

A — Action

I started by listening — I spent time in their world before proposing anything: sitting in on their daily dispute resolution process, understanding exactly how billing data failures manifested in their workflows, and documenting their pain points in their language, not technical language. I then proposed a narrowly scoped early win: a single, high-visibility traceability improvement in the auditing stage that would directly reduce their most frequent pain point. I delivered it on time, communicated clearly throughout, and followed up with a plain-language summary of what changed and why it mattered to them. That first delivery shifted the dynamic. Over subsequent months, they became active partners — flagging data anomalies early, participating in architecture reviews, and escalating on my behalf when engineering resources were needed.

R — Result

The relationship became one of the most productive cross-functional partnerships I've had. The stakeholders' active engagement significantly accelerated the broader traceability pipeline improvements and reduced dispute resolution cycles at scale.

Delivery Tip: Brandon will probe whether you understand what 'trusted advisor' actually means — it's not about being technically impressive, it's about making the other person feel heard and then consistently delivering. Use the phrase 'I started by listening.'

QUESTION 8 OF 15

Tell me about a time you had to work across teams you didn't control to deliver a complex technical programme.

[Cross-Functional Orchestration | Influence Without Authority | Delivery]

S — Situation

The Supply Chain data platform at Verizon required coordinating across data engineering, cloud infrastructure, partner integration teams, supply chain operations, and multiple external OEM and 3PL partners — none of whom reported to me. Each group had its own priorities, timelines, and definitions of done.

T — Task

I needed to create a unified delivery motion across these teams and hold the programme together without formal authority over any of them.

A — Action

I established a clear RACI at the start of the programme and spent time upfront getting each team lead to explicitly agree to their responsibilities — not just a memo, but a conversation where they shaped the plan. I created a shared execution tracker that each team owned their portion of, which made progress visible without feeling like surveillance. I ran a weekly programme governance cadence where each workstream reported status against milestones, and I explicitly surfaced blockers early rather than letting teams absorb delays silently. When priorities conflicted, I escalated to the right level with a clear recommendation — not just the problem. For external partners, I treated every integration milestone as a joint commitment and shared the delivery plan with their technical leads so they had visibility into downstream dependencies.

R — Result

The platform delivered on time across all workstreams, including the external OEM and 3PL integrations. The programme governance model I established was referenced by leadership as a template for subsequent multi-party data platform deliveries.

Delivery Tip: This maps directly to the DSA role: you orchestrate PS, field SAs, Shared Services, Support, and Product — none of whom report to you. Use the phrase 'I created certainty from a lot of moving parts.'

QUESTION 9 OF 15

Tell me about a time you had to make a difficult architecture decision with incomplete information.

[Technical Judgment | Decision Making | Architecture]

S — Situation

During the design phase of the Supply Chain data platform at Verizon, I needed to choose between a pure real-time streaming architecture and a hybrid streaming-plus-batch approach for ingesting partner data. The OEM partners had not yet finalized their data contract specifications, and the latency requirements from operations were still being negotiated — I had to make a foundational architectural decision before all the facts were known.

T — Task

Delaying the decision would push the delivery timeline. I needed to make a defensible, reversible call with the information available.

A — Action

I framed the decision around what we knew with confidence (high data volume, heterogeneous schemas, multi-partner fan-in), what was still uncertain (exact latency SLAs, partner API reliability), and what the cost of being wrong was in each direction. I chose a hybrid architecture: a real-time event-driven pipeline for time-sensitive flows, with a batch reconciliation layer for settlement and correction — designed so either layer could be tuned independently without re-architecting the other. I documented the decision and the assumptions it rested on, built in a 30-day architecture review checkpoint once partner specs were finalized, and communicated the rationale clearly to engineering and product stakeholders so they understood what would change if the assumptions proved wrong.

R — Result

When partner data contracts were finalized, the assumptions held in all but one case, requiring a targeted adjustment to the batch layer only — not a re-architecture. The hybrid design absorbed the uncertainty cleanly.

Delivery Tip: Brandon comes from a data engineering background — he'll appreciate the technical reasoning. Walk through your decision framework clearly: what you knew, what you didn't, and why your choice was reversible. Avoid making it sound like you guessed.

QUESTION 10 OF 15

Tell me about a time you attributed clear business value to a technical project and used that to drive stakeholder buy-in.

[Business Value | Stakeholder Communication | ROI]

S — Situation

The Agentic AI initiative at Verizon was not part of any approved roadmap. To pursue it, I needed to secure buy-in from engineering leadership and product management — who were rightly focused on committed deliverables — without a pre-existing budget or sponsor.

T — Task

I needed to translate a technical concept (LLM-based workflow automation) into a business case that non-technical stakeholders would fund and prioritize.

A — Action

I started by quantifying the current cost of the manual process: I worked with the operations team to measure the average analyst time spent per workflow cycle, multiplied by volume and frequency, and expressed it in hours and dollars annually. I then built a conservative projection of the automated alternative — not best-case, but defensible — and expressed the delta as both cost savings and cycle time reduction. I presented this as a two-slide business case: the cost of doing nothing vs. the projected ROI of a six-week prototype. I was explicit about risks and what assumptions the ROI rested on. The prototype was approved, delivered on schedule, and the results validated the projections.

R — Result

The initiative was approved and delivered, compressing process cycles from weeks to near-real-time and reclaiming thousands of analyst hours annually. The business case approach I used became my standard template for pitching platform investments.

Delivery Tip: DSAs live in this space — translating technical investments into business outcomes executives care about. Use the phrase 'I never lead with technology; I lead with the business problem and let the technology earn its place.'

QUESTION 11 OF 15

Tell me about a time a project you were leading hit a significant obstacle. How did you respond?

[Resilience | Problem Solving | Accountability]

S — Situation

During the integration phase of the Supply Chain data platform at Verizon, one of the major OEM partners encountered a data format inconsistency in their outbound feeds that hadn't been identified during the discovery phase. The inconsistency affected the core real-time ingestion pipeline and surfaced less than four weeks before the committed go-live date.

T — Task

As the technical owner, I was accountable for the go-live date. Delaying would have business and contractual implications. Rushing a fix risked introducing data integrity issues into a platform that \$20M in savings depended on.

A — Action

I immediately convened a focused working session with the data engineering team and the OEM's technical team to scope the problem precisely — not to brainstorm, but to answer three questions: How bad is it? Can we fix it cleanly in time? If not, what's the safe partial go-live? Within 48 hours we had a clear picture: the inconsistency affected one of five data streams. I proposed a phased go-live: launch four streams on schedule, implement a validated fix for the fifth stream within two additional weeks. I communicated this to stakeholders not as a delay but as a risk-managed sequencing decision, with the business impact of the affected stream quantified so they could make an informed call. Leadership approved the phased approach.

R — Result

The platform launched on the original date with four of five streams live. The fifth stream went live 12 days later — within the proposed window. The overall \$20M savings outcome was not materially impacted by the phased approach.

Delivery Tip: Brandon wants to see that you stay calm, narrow the problem fast, and give stakeholders options with trade-offs — not just problems. Close with: 'My job is to turn uncertainty into a decision, not to absorb it.'

QUESTION 12 OF 15

Tell me about a time you mentored or enabled a team to develop a technical capability they didn't have before.

[Enablement | Team Development | Platform Adoption]

S — Situation

At Verizon, after designing the cloud-native data platform architecture, I identified that several data engineers on the teams consuming the platform lacked hands-on experience with event-driven pipeline patterns and data traceability design — skills that were critical for maintaining and extending what I'd built.

T — Task

If the teams couldn't own the platform independently, my work would create a dependency on me rather than a scalable capability. I needed to transfer knowledge systematically.

A — Action

I built a structured enablement programme rather than ad-hoc knowledge transfer. I created practical, example-based documentation — not theoretical, but drawn from the actual production platform — covering the event-driven pipeline patterns, traceability design, and operational runbooks. I ran a series of hands-on workshops where engineers worked through real pipeline scenarios using the reference architecture, with me in a coaching role rather than providing answers. I also introduced architecture review pairing — where I'd review design proposals with engineers before they were finalized, so learning happened in context. Over several months I shifted from being a reviewer to an occasional advisor as the team's confidence grew.

R — Result

Within six months, the teams were independently designing and delivering new pipelines on the platform without requiring my involvement in day-to-day architecture decisions. Two engineers on the team went on to lead their own platform initiatives. Clean handoff is a success metric I'm proud of.

Delivery Tip: This directly maps to the DSA's enablement and user growth responsibilities. Use the phrase 'my goal was to make myself unnecessary for day-to-day decisions.' Brandon will recognize that as the right instinct.

QUESTION 13 OF 15

Tell me about a time you had to evaluate competing vendor or technology options and make a recommendation under pressure.

[Technical Evaluation | Vendor Assessment | Stakeholder Communication]

S — Situation

At Verizon, I was tasked with evaluating integration and tooling options for a component of the data platform — specifically, options for a data orchestration and transformation layer where multiple vendor and open-source alternatives existed, each with different cost, performance, governance, and long-term maintainability profiles.

T — Task

Engineering and product stakeholders had different preferences and partial information. A decision was needed quickly to avoid blocking the delivery timeline.

A — Action

I structured the evaluation around the criteria that actually mattered for our context: total cost of ownership, compatibility with our existing AWS infrastructure, maturity for enterprise production use, and the team's ability to own it without heavy vendor dependency. I built a simple scoring matrix against those criteria — not to generate a number to hide behind, but to make the trade-offs explicit and discussable. I ran a focused technical proof-of-concept for the top two options against a real use case from our pipeline, measuring actual performance rather than relying on vendor benchmarks. I then presented the recommendation with the full trade-off analysis — including the risks of my recommended option — so stakeholders could challenge the reasoning, not just the conclusion.

R — Result

The recommendation was accepted with strong stakeholder alignment because the evaluation process was transparent and defensible. The selected tooling performed as projected in production and required less operational overhead than the alternative.

Delivery Tip: Brandon will be evaluating whether you can make a call and defend it. The key is showing you gave stakeholders the trade-offs, not just the answer — that's what makes it advisory rather than just technical.

QUESTION 14 OF 15

Tell me about a time you had to create a strategic roadmap for a customer or stakeholder and get alignment across multiple groups.

[Strategic Planning | Roadmap | Executive Alignment]

S — Situation

Following the initial go-live of the Supply Chain data platform at Verizon, stakeholders had a wide range of ideas for what to build next — new data sources, new analytical capabilities, AI features, cost optimization work — and no shared view of priority. Without a roadmap, the platform risked being pulled in multiple directions and losing coherence.

T — Task

I needed to synthesize inputs from supply chain operations, finance, engineering, and product into a single, prioritized platform roadmap that everyone could execute against.

A — Action

I ran a structured roadmap workshop with representatives from each stakeholder group. Rather than asking 'what do you want?', I anchored the conversation in outcomes: 'What decisions do you need to make better, faster, or cheaper in the next 12 months?' I collected the resulting capability needs, mapped them against the existing platform architecture to assess build complexity and dependency, and scored them on a two-by-two of business value vs. delivery effort. I drafted the roadmap in three horizons: quick wins in the next 90 days to maintain momentum, core capability builds in 6 months, and strategic investments in 12 months. I presented it to each stakeholder group separately before a joint alignment session, incorporating their input so they arrived at the joint session with their concerns already addressed.

R — Result

The roadmap was approved with alignment across all stakeholder groups — including finance and operations, which had historically disagreed on platform priorities. It became the basis for the next two years of platform investment decisions.

Delivery Tip: Roadmap creation is a core DSA deliverable at Databricks. Use the phrase 'I anchor roadmaps in outcomes, not features.' Walk Brandon through the three-horizon structure — it signals strategic thinking.

QUESTION 15 OF 15

Tell me about a time you proactively identified and resolved a risk before it became a problem.

[Risk Management | Proactivity | Technical Accountability]

S — Situation

Several months into the operation of the B2B Billing data platform at Verizon, I noticed during a routine pipeline review that the volume of data flowing through the ingestion layer was growing at a rate that would exceed the platform's provisioned capacity within approximately three months — well before the next planned infrastructure review cycle.

T — Task

No one had flagged this as a risk. If left unaddressed, it would have resulted in pipeline latency degradation and potential data loss for the 2,000+ enterprise clients the platform served — with billing and contractual implications.

A — Action

I modelled the growth trajectory using three months of volume data and produced a capacity forecast with upper and lower bounds. I translated the technical risk into a business impact framing — not 'we'll hit capacity limits,' but 'here's when client billing data will start degrading and what the commercial exposure looks like.' I brought this to engineering and platform leadership with a concrete proposal: a phased capacity uplift plan with two options (proactive scaling vs. architectural optimization) and my recommended path with cost and risk trade-offs. I secured approval for the recommended approach and executed it within six weeks — before the risk window arrived.

R — Result

The platform scaled without any client-facing degradation or data loss. The capacity forecasting model I built was subsequently embedded into the platform's ongoing operational health monitoring.

Delivery Tip: This is a pure trusted advisor story — you didn't wait to be asked, you saw the risk and created certainty. Brandon values DSAs who operate proactively, not reactively. Close with: 'My job is to make sure my stakeholders are never surprised.'

Remember: every answer should feel like a conversation, not a recitation. Lead with the result when the result is strong — then tell the story.